



We hope it does not launch by the time the issue is out.

OUTRAGEOUS IAPs



Bags of gems, wagons of gold or bushels of smurfberries are various kinds of digital currencies. The developers of these charge outrageous amounts of real world money for these totally made up in-game premium currencies. Extra characters, consumables, skins are all the various kinds of predatory IAP practices that bad games can use, without charging a fair price for the content and value they are providing. The prices can be astronomical, and in the hands of those addicted to the game, or young children, especially with indulgent parents, the overpriced IAP can be a viable revenue stream in an overcrowded market. A good idea is to check games of your children for IAP, and make sure that none of the games are charging more than you are willing to pay for any single item. If that is the case, the game is probably predatory, and it is better to simply uninstall it.

FREEMIUM/F2P



This is actually a great model for consumers who can get into a game for free, and purchase only the aspects of the game that they feel is worth investing in. The entire player base becomes the content itself. Players can either pay to progress through the game faster, in which case it becomes pay to win, or pay for cosmetics and animation that have vanity value, but not actually affect the gameplay. The problem is that this is a sustainable model only for very large games. Additionally, very few games manage to implement the purchase options in a manner that feels fair to the people who are buying the content. A vast majority of the games using this model only look to trap you in the game, and fooling you into playing. Once you have invested your time in the game, and you suddenly need to pay up for progressing further, you are more likely to do it at that point of time,

as against paying for something up front before starting the game.

ADWARE



In the early days of smartphones, there were many games and apps that were genuinely free. Now you will be hard pressed to find a free game that is not ad supported. The problem is that there is no way of telling what kind of ads get delivered to you, and when they will pop up. We have played some games where the ads pop up suddenly in the middle of a good streak where you are close to getting a high score. Another problem is inappropriate ads. These can show in kids apps, or when you are in a public place. While they are not outright pornographic, they can certainly be very vulgar. Even the ad supported applications from relatively good publishers are liable to deliver all sorts of ads, because they're using ad networks and not screening the ads they display themselves. We have nothing against the model per se, because we want developers to make money, but we feel there should be more accountability for ad delivery networks, and we should at least get to choose age appropriate ads. App stores should certainly do a better job of policing them. You can just turn off mobile internet while playing the game, but it's a bit of a pain.

TIME SINKS



A number of games have started incorporating time sinks in their games. There are just timers in the game that prevent you from playing, unless you wait out the duration of the countdown, or pay up. These are periods where you are kept away from the action for absolutely no reason. Even in the games where they seem to have a strategic role, such as the rate at which new buildings can be built inside a simulator game, the time sinks can be made to go away by paying money. In other games, such as puzzle games or fighting games, the reason the time sinks are in there is to purely extract more money from the users, or make them do the same by watching advertisements as a proxy. This is just an irritating "mechanic" that needs to go away.



It is a good idea to get them in bulk